ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Reporting passives

Reporting passives shift attention from the person making the claim to the reported information, while signalling that the claim comes from another source.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Attribute claims with appropriate distance and formal register.

Attribute information with it is said that or subject + is said to, especially in news, formal reports and cautious summaries.

MODEL

People believe she left. -> She is believed to have left.

it + be + reporting participle + that-clause | subject + be + reporting participle + to-infinitive

6 GUIDED STAGES · 29 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Transform active reports into two passive patterns.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a simple or perfect infinitive from the time relationship.

OUTCOME 3

03

Attribute information without presenting an unverified claim as fact.

Build meaning before form

Attribute information with it is said that or subject + is said to, especially in news, formal reports and cautious summaries.

Two structures for one report

It is reported that keeps the complete proposition after that. The company is reported to… promotes the subject of the proposition and makes it the grammatical topic.

The promoted-subject pattern is compact and common in headlines, profiles and formal summaries; the impersonal pattern is useful when the whole claim deserves equal attention.

Simple or perfect infinitive

Use a simple infinitive when the reported situation is simultaneous with, or later than, the report: He is thought to live abroad. Use a perfect infinitive when the reported event happened earlier: He is thought to have left.

Passive meaning inside the infinitive may require to have been + past participle, as in The manuscript is thought to have been written in 1150.

Time relationship	Form	Example
simultaneous/later	to + base form	He is thought to live abroad.
earlier	to have + participle	He is thought to have left.

Reporting verbs change the stance

Said, believed, thought, reported, understood, expected and alleged do not carry identical meanings. Alleged marks a disputed claim; expected points towards a prediction; understood suggests shared or indirect knowledge.

Choose the participle that accurately represents both the source and the writer’s commitment.

Accuracy and source responsibility

A reporting passive marks attribution; it does not prove that the claim is true. Reliable writing names the source whenever the reader needs to assess authority: According to the inspection report…

Use the passive for information structure, not as a substitute for evidence.

Reason through the pattern

One active report divides into two routes: impersonal it or a promoted subject. A time checkpoint then selects the simple or perfect infinitive.

01	02	03	04	05	06	07	08
it	be	reporting participle	that-clause	subject	be	reporting participle	to-infinitive

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Use impersonal it when the whole proposition should remain after that.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Promote the reported subject when it should become the topic.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Use to have + past participle for an event earlier than the reporting time.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Name the source explicitly when credibility or accountability matters.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Active report	Impersonal it	Promoted subject
People say he is wealthy.	It is said that he is wealthy.	He is said to be wealthy.
They believe she left.	It is believed that she left.	She is believed to have left.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

People say he is...	He is said to be...
They believe she left.	She is believed to have left.
Experts expect prices to rise.	Prices are expected to rise.

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Using to left instead of to have left.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Changing the time relationship during the transformation.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Using a passive to hide a source that readers need to evaluate.

Recognition in context

Choose the form that completes each situation naturally.

A1 · CONTEXT 1

The scientist is believed ___ the discovery in 1998.

OPTIONS to have made · to make · to made · having make

A2 · CONTEXT 2

The actor is said ___ in Lisbon now.

OPTIONS to live · to have lived · living · lives

A3 · CONTEXT 3

___ that the policy will change next year.

OPTIONS It is expected · It expects · There is expected · It has expect

A4 · CONTEXT 4

Prices are expected ___ further.

OPTIONS to rise · to have risen · rising · rise to

A5 · CONTEXT 5

The manuscript is thought ___ in the twelfth century.

OPTIONS to have been written · to be written · to wrote · having written

A6 · CONTEXT 6

People say the firm is in talks. -> The firm ___ in talks.

OPTIONS is said to be · is said that it is · says to be · has said be

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

02 · PRACTICE STAGE

Two connected decisions

Resolve two connected choices within the same context.

B1 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 1

It _____ that the data were altered. Two accounts _____ to have been affected.

OPTIONS Gap 1: is alleged / alleges / is alleging · Gap 2: are believed / believe / are believing

B2 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 2

The CEO _____ to be considering a sale, and the board _____ to have met yesterday.

OPTIONS Gap 1: is reported / reports / is reporting · Gap 2: is understood / understands / is understanding

B3 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 3

It _____ that the painting is genuine. It _____ to have belonged to a royal family.

OPTIONS Gap 1: is thought / thinks / thought · Gap 2: is said / says / is saying

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided text

Maintain the target structure throughout a complete text.

C1 · GUIDED APPLICATION

A rare document _____ to have been found in a private archive. It _____ that it dates from 1520. The author _____ to have worked for the royal court, and the text _____ to contain previously unknown details. Experts _____ to be examining the paper now.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

are understanding · are understood · believes · has believe · is believed · is reported · is reporting · is said · is thinking · is thought · reports · said · says · thinks · understand

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open text

Supply every form without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT APPLICATION

People believe the minister resigned. -> The minister _____. Experts say the bridge is safe. -> The bridge _____. They report that two people were injured. -> It _____. People expect the talks to continue. -> The talks _____. Historians think the city was founded earlier. -> The city _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled production

Transform the idea without changing its meaning.

E1 · CONTROLLED TASK 1

Transform: People say she speaks six languages.

_____
_____

E2 · CONTROLLED TASK 2

Transform: They believe the suspect left the country.

_____
_____

E3 · CONTROLLED TASK 3

Transform: Experts expect inflation will fall.

_____
_____

E4 · CONTROLLED TASK 4

Correct: He is thought to left yesterday.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative mission

Use the structure in original responses and realistic situations.

F1 · COMMUNICATION TASK 1

Write an original Reporting passives response for context 1. Include it is reported, are believed to.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · COMMUNICATION TASK 2

Write an original Reporting passives response for context 2. Include is thought to, is believed to have.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · COMMUNICATION TASK 3

Write an original Reporting passives response for context 3. Include is believed to be, according to.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: passive.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: to-infinitive.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: to have.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: source.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

to have made

Use “to have made”. Use impersonal it when the whole proposition should remain after that.

A2

to live

Use “to live”. Promote the reported subject when it should become the topic.

A3

It is expected

Use “It is expected”. Use to have + past participle for an event earlier than the reporting time.

A4

to rise

Use “to rise”. Name the source explicitly when credibility or accountability matters.

A5

to have been written

Use “to have been written”. Use impersonal it when the whole proposition should remain after that.

A6

is said to be

Use “is said to be”. Promote the reported subject when it should become the topic.

Two connected decisions

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

is alleged / are believed

Use “is alleged”. Use impersonal it when the whole proposition should remain after that. Use “are believed”. Promote the reported subject when it should become the topic.

B2

is reported / is understood

Use “is reported”. Promote the reported subject when it should become the topic. Use “is understood”. Use to have + past participle for an event earlier than the reporting time.

B3

is thought / is said

Use “is thought”. Use to have + past participle for an event earlier than the reporting time. Use “is said”. Name the source explicitly when credibility or accountability matters.

Guided text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

is reported

Use “is reported”. Use impersonal it when the whole proposition should remain after that.

C2

is believed

Use “is believed”. Promote the reported subject when it should become the topic.

C3

is thought

Use “is thought”. Use to have + past participle for an event earlier than the reporting time.

C4

is said

Use “is said”. Name the source explicitly when credibility or accountability matters.

C5

are understood

Use “are understood”. Use impersonal it when the whole proposition should remain after that.

Open text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

is believed to have resigned

Use “is believed to have resigned”. Use impersonal it when the whole proposition should remain after that.

D2

is said to be safe

Use “is said to be safe”. Promote the reported subject when it should become the topic.

D3

is reported that two people were injured

Use “is reported that two people were injured”. Use to have + past participle for an event earlier than the reporting time.

D4

are expected to continue

Use “are expected to continue”. Name the source explicitly when credibility or accountability matters.

D5

is thought to have been founded earlier

Use “is thought to have been founded earlier”. Use impersonal it when the whole proposition should remain after that.

Controlled production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

She is said to speak six languages.

Use “She is said to speak six languages.”. Use impersonal it when the whole proposition should remain after that.

E2

The suspect is believed to have left the country.

Use “The suspect is believed to have left the country.”. Promote the reported subject when it should become the topic.

E3

It is expected that inflation will fall.

Use “It is expected that inflation will fall.”. Use to have + past participle for an event earlier than the reporting time.

E4

He is thought to have left yesterday.

Use “He is thought to have left yesterday.”. Name the source explicitly when credibility or accountability matters.

Communicative mission

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

It is reported that the talks have resumed. Both sides are believed to be close to an agreement.

The model combines accurate Reporting passives with a clear purpose. Use impersonal it when the whole proposition should remain after that.

F2

The treatment is thought to be effective. Its success is believed to have resulted from the new dosage.

The model combines accurate Reporting passives with a clear purpose. Promote the reported subject when it should become the topic.

F3

The area is believed to be safe; according to the council report, inspections ended on Friday.

The model combines accurate Reporting passives with a clear purpose. Use to have + past participle for an event earlier than the reporting time.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____